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Jack Goody

Life story interview with Paul Thompson

2008

Principle investigator's thematic highlights

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Sir Jack Goody

Interviewed by Paul Thompson

11-12 June 2008

1. Parents

Neither of my parents did secondary education – but they were very interested in education. My mother stayed with the Post Office in London until she married. She was a clerk then. In that time, of course, women in the Civil Service couldn't remain when they married, they had to move out. So as a result of this, we - my brother and I - received our mother's attention, which was certainly very Scottish... But as far as Scottishness and education was concerned, she was very concerned with that, yes. And, of course, having been sacked by the Post Office when she married, she spent all her time with my brother and I on our education … My brother was a Fellow here too, before he went to Harvard. And he told me, the other day, that he thinks we are the ... only two brothers, who are Fellows of the National Academy of Sciences in America – so that was as a result of my Scottish upbringing … my semi-Scottish upbringing, and my uneducated mother and father.

PT: Was your mother a keen reader, then?

JG: Yes. My father was, above all, a keen reader. He was a very keen reader, and had a lot of books around him … all 18th century novels and so on he had, and he used to read us those on Sunday evenings. Yes, he was a very keen reader... My father read a lot, but he had left school quite early, and he had become an apprentice in the electricity trade, … and after the War, he became, eventually, an advertising manager in electricity … He did a lot of writing, I think, as a journalist, of a technical kind, so he was a good writer. And when I first started publishing up here, I used to get him to correct my proofs, which he was very good at, so he was really good on that side. But, no, I didn't discuss very much with him, partly because my own interest in literature was much later, you know, was 19th century and 20th century, and partly because politically, he was a reader of the *Daily*

Telegraph, and I rather followed my mother, who was a reader of the *News Chronicle*, so I didn't really have a lot to speak to him about that.

PT: And would you say that, emotionally, you were close to them, or not?

JG: Yes. Yes, I was, emotionally, I think. And remained so... There's a great attachment, even though we didn't show it, perhaps, very much. (pp 2-4)

2. St Alban's School, 1930-38

PT: I'm trying to understand how you developed intellectual interests …

JG: I think it was much more at school than anything else...

There was no secondary school in Welwyn Garden City at that time, and I think the secondary school, in County terms, was probably at Stevenage. But my parents decided to send me to St. Albans, which was a private school, as a day boy, so I travelled over as a day boy there, and I suppose that was really formative for me, from an intellectual point of view. It was there that I became interested in doing something in English, in literature. It was there my brother decided to do something in physics.

PT: Were there particular teachers who were important influences?

JG: Oh yes. I had a teacher who... was very much influenced by Leavis and by *Scrutiny*, so I read *Scrutiny* from an early age. And he was an important influence on me. (p 6)

3. Cambridge: Socialism and English Literature, 1938-39 and 1945-46

JG: Well, I suppose, as far as I was concerned, in English, obviously Leavis and his acolytes were very influential all round the place, I mean right through the University. In here, in St. John's, I suppose I was very interested by my Supervisor, who was Hugh

Sykes Davies, who ran the first surrealist exhibition in London, or … I don't know whether he ran it, he was involved, and wrote a surrealist novel. But he was also a Marxist, and, indeed, was suspected of being the fifth member of the Cambridge spy network at one time, and was a member of the Apostles and so on, that people in Trinity were all members of. So he was important to me. Because one has to remember …
When I went up, I had been heavily politicised at school – not because of school - because of my friends, I suppose, but because of what was happening in the world, because of Spain and so on, … So the Spanish War and everything was very important.

PT: Did you think of going there yourself?

JG: No. No, I never did. … I don't know why. Well, partly because I was having a great struggle in myself between pacifism and some more active resistance, because I had an aunt - well, she wasn't really an aunt, she was a friend of my mother's – they were in the Post Office together – she also came from the North of Scotland, right up North by Dounreay, and she was a follower of Gandhi, and a vegetarian, and a pacifist, who took me to lunch, I can remember, at Heals in Tottenham Court Road, because they had a vegetarian part of the restaurant, or menu, there, so I was much impressed by her, and by the whole of the Pacifist Movement. So it was a great struggle for me with Spain, as the whole problem of arms for Spain was whether that was the best thing or not. I suppose it was partly Guernica that resolved my doubts about that. (pp 9-10)

It was natural that when I came up here I should join CUSC – the Socialist Club.

PT: Cambridge University Socialist Club?

JG: Yes. Which was extremely interesting, in the sense that that's where I met my friend Eric Hobsbawm, and … he was a leader of men … I mean, he was one of the big figures of the Socialist Club. He … was two years ahead or something, or three years ahead, and he was very Continental... He knew about what was going on in France and Austria and so on, whereas the problem about Leavis and the English school, and perhaps any English school, was that they were so concerned with the English tradition, not like most of you

historians, but they were worse - you know, they had this tradition... and excluded everybody else, obviously English tradition had to... (pp 11-12)

I remember, at one stage, going over to Paris with Eric and E.P. Thompson. E.P... Edward was very much the English historian. You know, he didn't think the French Revolution had much effect on England, he thought it was all to do with these Muggletonians or whoever in 18th century England, and he was devoted to the English tradition again. But Eric was a different kettle of fish. Much more Continental, much more wider view of the world …

PT: When did you meet Raymond Williams? Was that at this stage?

JG: Raymond I met after the War. Raymond, another Leavis product. My friend, George Scurfield, came back from the War at the same time as I did. Indeed, there were a lot of us here at that time, like my friend Ian Watt that I wrote this article on literacy with, and he started me off, really, on that line of thinking. And that arose out of the English novel, incidentally, because he was a great man on Defoe, and he wrote this book on the English novel...

And we travelled together in France directly after the War, and we went to visit... Little Gidding [the setting for one of T. S. Eliot's *Four Quartets*]... I can remember going there with Ian, after the War, in the snow - it was in the snow at Little Gidding too, and drinking a bottle of brandy … with my friend, George Scurfield. (pp 12-13)

4. Sandhurst and Communism, 1939

JG: We started a small group in Sandhurst – not exactly a Communist Group, because … by then we'd become rather dissatisfied with the British Communist Party's line on the War... Yes, I went straight from here to Sandhurst.

PT: And is that because you were a Cambridge undergraduate that you were presumed to be …

JG: Well, I'd been … at school I'd been in Officer Training Corps, and had got quite high up in it, I suppose. So it was partly that and partly sort of Cambridge and so on, and also partly because, here, when war broke out, we had to volunteer for something or other. … We were very much imbued with Spain and the anti-Fascist struggle, and these manoeuvres of the Soviet Union and so on were not much to our liking at the time.

PT: But had you earlier actually joined the Communist Party?

JG: Oh yes.

PT: You had? Yes.

JG: Six months before, I suppose...

PT: And then did you leave it?

JG: Well, not deliberately. I mean, I just didn't know anything about it! I didn't keep up with it, and some were much more against the Soviet Union and its war on Finland, of course, but I was certainly against the Ribbentrop Pact, because so much of one's side had been devoted to struggling against that very thing. (pp 17-18)

5. Prisoner-of-War: 1942-43

We went to Egypt to fight and move up to the desert. We went to the pyramids. We were camped near the Giza Pyramids, in camp, and I can remember going to the Great Pyramid in the morning, and getting my platoon to clamber up, as part of the morning exercise, and I don't remember doing it myself!

But then we went off to the desert, and after a short while I was captured in Tobruk, and flown over.... in June of 1942.… So we were put into camp, and then eventually taken to Bengazi, and flown back to Italy...

And then we went by train, to … a place called Chieti – which now has a University of Chieti – and we were in a prison camp there. …It was a large courtyard area with various brick-built huts on it … and an open area in the middle, and a wall around it... It held all the junior officers captured in the desert, it held them there. And we had Italian guards in tall pill-boxes situated around the camp.

PT: And what sort of regime was there?

JG: Well, the regime was not particularly harsh, in that sense. We just had roll call every day. You see, as officers, under the Geneva Convention – which the Italians observed, even if the Americans don't – officers did not work. They got less food than other ranks - soldiers who could work outside, but they were not made to work. So we had nothing to do. But we were all young officers about my age, many of us had been at university or something like that, and we started up, soon after we got there, we started up a vigorous educational programme, really it was very extensive – for everything, including the priesthood – and I can remember teaching some English literature, but also taking a course in psychology and Italian and other things...

PT: And I think you said that there was a theatre in the camp?

JG: Yes, very rigorous theatre, in which my friend, David Smith-Dorien, one of these young officers in the Regiment, I told you about, who had been in the theatre before, and was again afterwards, he was very rigorous in that. And we had an interesting theatrical programme. The big dining room, which turned into a theatre, and every month we had one classical play; we had one West End production that we remembered – we had to remember these; we had one play that somebody wrote in the camp; and we had one musical, something like this; and every Saturday we had a kind of Music Hall …. And on Sunday, we used to have music. We didn't have many scores, but we could get, through the Red Cross, we got a gramophone, and we had somebody who became a music master at Marlborough I think … anyhow, he was a member of the British Academy later on, and he used to sit down ... with his gramophone, and score – write out – what he heard, for the instruments that we had, which were few and far between. And he used to give a symphony concert every Sunday afternoon. And we had a booking office in the

camp, run by somebody called Tennant, who, I'm sure, was related to the booking people in London, in which you would get your ticket for a certain performance. It was very well-organised in that sense...

The teaching, too, was highly organised - a timetable. And what we didn't have much of was reading material, and we had no library... In Italy we had no books at all, virtually, until the very end of the time, when we started getting some book parcels from England.

PT: Were you impressed by the way that all this cultural activity was created out of nothing?

JG: Very. Very impressed. Well, when you see a lot of soldiers walking down the street, you don't immediately think of someone amongst them teaching Freud or Pavlov, or whatever! But yes, it was extraordinary, really, how this grew up suddenly – both on the artistic side and on the intellectual side. It was very interesting. (pp 20-23)

6. Escaped Prisoner-of-War 1943-44

PT: You said that the diversity of people you mixed with in this phase aroused your curiosity. Could you explain about that?

JG: Well, I don't know if I can say much more, but you were thrown up against people in very close contact, and in the group that I was in, they came from my Regiment, and we'd all been taken prisoners together... When I escaped, which I escaped for six months, even more so, I mean, I was in a cave … later on with some South Africans and two guys who, I think, were Nottinghamshire miners. But anyhow, people who were in a completely different way of life, and … because all the things that I've been describing to you - you know, school, university - you were simply somebody concerned with books and books and books, you weren't concerned with doing things like cutting up meat or even acting on the stage, so it was very different in that way. So I think you met a lot of people with a lot of different experiences, and particularly, as I say, many of the people in my regiment I met then and afterwards, were Nottinghamshire miners, who had joined the Regular

Army because they were out of a job. … This was the sort of person that you were meeting.

PT: But you were also coming across very different cultures, weren't you …

JG: Well, I was... Of course, if you were in a military camp, it didn't matter whether you were in Iraq or Afghanistan, you didn't learn much about what happened around you... It was more particularly … after I'd been in Italy, at the end of the Armistice there when I escaped for six months, then I was with villagers, … and lived very close and had to live in houses, in villagers' houses, to get food and to get a night's rest... (pp 23-24)

7. Prisoner-of War at Eichstätt: 1944-45 – the library

JG: Eichstätt was quite different, yes, and had this excellent library. When I got to Eichstätt, there were people there who had been there since Dunkerque. They received a lot of books all the time, because you were allowed to send a parcel of books every month or two, or something – I forget what it was – but anyhow, we had a very good collection of books in Eichstätt, so I was able, there, to read. Well, the two books I remember were Chambers's *Mediaeval Stage* and *The Golden Bough*, which, of course, were mentioned in T.S. Eliot's *Wasteland*, which is why I started reading it...

PT: There was another book you mentioned, Gordon Childe, *What Happened in History*.

JG: Yes. I was very impressed with Gordon Childe, principally because … he made sense to me of something I'd never really thought about, and that was the Middle East and so on – where I went. And I remember, in Cyprus, when I was in Cyprus, going round a museum there and seeing a clay model of a bullock, from the third … millennium BC, of a bullock pulling a plough, and it was precisely the same sort of Mediterranean plough that Marc Bloch talks about, or that you see … going around … a scratch ground, scratching the surface of the land, and the continuity of that, and the fact that that was still being used, yes, … impressed me very much. So I was very impressed all the time, and have been ever since, with the achievements of the Bronze Age and … and writing, which

writing was what, and how they affected modern society... Childe made sense of these things very much. So I was very impressed with Childe. Very impressed.

PT: And would it be true that these books were crucial in your decision to become an anthropologist?

JG: Well, I suppose so. There were various things, of course, but obviously the reading was one thing. Another thing would have been the theatre. Quite apart from the books, you came in contact with other cultures in a different way, and particularly in Italy where I got very close to people, but also in Cyprus as well, to some extent. … I was also interested in the wider problem … of human conflict... And also in the Tavi [the Tavistock Institute of Human Relations]. The Tavi's interest, to me, was the avoidance of … of human conflict.

PT: So how did you come into contact with them?

JG: Well (a) because they had a special dispensational grant or whatever, from the government, of looking after prisoners-of-war, so when I came back afterwards, there was an invitation to go to the Tavi if I wanted to. I didn't, in fact, go. But there was an article which I read, by Edward Shils, in private papers about American sociology, which talked about the rapprochement with psychology and with psychoanalysis, and mentioned the Tavi, and the letter I had from Edward Shils, I think that's how I came in contact with them.

PT: And anthropology, was that just an idea, because you've mentioned Fraser, but there's no other person you've mentioned.

JG: Not really. That was just an idea. I mean, it wasn't till I came back here and started reading anthropology that I knew about Evans-Pritchard, for example. (pp 27-29)

8. Adult Education: 1947-49

So I first remember - my memory of Raymond [Williams], is, in fact, meeting him... in Adult Education. Because one of the interesting things that happened, and partly through the Army Bureau of Current Affairs, which was run by a Leavis Scholar, Ford... ABCA … led a number of us into Adult Education. My friend, George Scurfield, went into Adult Education before he decided he couldn't live on writing and became a postman, and Edward was in Adult Education, Raymond was in Adult Education. And when I came down from here after the War, I got a job in Further Education in Hertfordshire, for a couple of years. … I was living in Barnet, Friern Barnet … But, of course, so was Raymond and Edward [Thompson], but they were doing it at a higher level, they were doing it with University Extra-Mural.

PT: And what were you teaching, then?

JG: Jam-making! I wasn't really teaching, I was organising classes more than teaching. I can remember teaching jam-making. I did have one terrible experience trying to teach drama, or produce drama in some village in the north of Hertfordshire, and tried to get my class to read a play, but discovered that half of them couldn't read... I organised Youth Clubs and things like that, but I didn't do anything intellectual. It was then that I decided that I didn't want to live the rest of my life like this, I wanted to get back into academic work. (pp 14-15)

9. Oxford Anthropology, 1949-52: anthropology and history

I saw that the Colonial Service was... offering Scholarships to work abroad, and I applied for this post, this Scholarship, from the Colonial Service, to go and work in Oxford, because I was very disappointed by anthropology in Cambridge. The only decent lecturer was Evans-Pritchard who used to come over every week and do a session here, and he was particularly interesting whilst he was talking about war and peace, so I wanted to work over there. So I got a Scholarship from the Colonial Office and I went for a year to Oxford, to Balliol... (p 16)

When I went to Oxford, and they wanted me to work on Italian village life, I was told that first of all you had to learn about some other society, so that's why I went to Africa – never got back! (p 29)

It's Godfrey [Lienhardt] and Emrys [Peters] that I remember most from that year, and Godfrey - yes, he influenced me a lot, I think, because he'd also read English, whereas Emrys was a geographer.

PT: In what way did Godfrey influence you?

JG: Well, first towards Evans-Pritchard, I suppose.

PT: But in his own work, for instance, did you get ideas from him?

JG: No, not many. No, not really. I think that I was much more influenced by my friend Ian Watt, whom I told you about, who was interested in literacy and Defoe, rather than anybody else. (pp 32-34)

None of these people were very interested in historical work, partly because the Nuer had no written history, but I never thought they looked upon it much in that way, they looked upon it not as I did, as a matter of the historical dimension of technique as the influence, but in terms of something more spiritual, more nebulous. I always think of Levi-Strauss's distinction between the bricolage of the Neolithic, what he calls the "primitive mind" and other thinking. He never, once, thinks in terms of the mechanisms that transfer from one to the other with literacy, for example, how it made a difference. … And EP, I think, was something of the same. He was a historian by training...

PT: So did he not inspire you, as a lecturer?

JG: Yes, very much, as a teacher. Very much as a teacher, but particularly a lecture on the Nuer, about Nuer conflicts and the resolution of conflicts, and since I'd just come out of the Army and spent my life, so far, being involved in conflicts, and as I say, picked up *The Journal of Conflict Studies*, I was particularly interested in that aspect of what he did.

But also, in the sense it's got to be said, that he looked at conflict from a structural rather than an historical point of view, and I must say that interested me a lot, and said that people with certain positions, they'd be much more likely to be in conflict than if they were in some other position – that sort of discussion which he raised, I think. And on the other hand, he was, in his way, very reactionary. Well, he was sort of radical reactionary. Very anti-authoritarian, but reactionary nevertheless, and certainly not interested in any ideas coming from the Left at all... (pp 30-31)

10. American sociologists

Reading Talcott Parsons, anthropology and psychology

Lloyd Warner, I knew him when he came to Cambridge. Well, I knew all those three American sociologists quite well. Meyer Fortes had been very strong in promoting this Chair in Sociology, but he thought you couldn't put a Chair in Sociology here without bringing some people in to validate it. He validated it with Talcott Parsons, George Holmans, and Lloyd Warner. And I knew all three of these very well, really, because I was one of the few people around interested in them. And when I'd gone to do my doctoral work in Oxford, which turned out to be a B.Litt. in the end, because Meyer Fortes had moved to Cambridge, and he thought I ought to do something for Oxford first, so I did a B.Litt. for Oxford before I did a Ph.D. here. But when I went to Oxford, I met Norman Birnbaum. I met a political scientist [Mel Richter], who had been at Harvard. He'd read English, like me, he was interested in the work of Talcott Parsons … He was at Balliol, because he did his first work on T.H. Green and company, and he used to speak about them as "his tribe". Anyhow, we were interested in the work of Parsons, and we used to sit down, we used to go to a café, for lunch, once a week, and we would construe a chapter of Parsons. And I mean construe. I mean, working out - working out his ideas and his syntax. So that when Parsons came to Cambridge, I was one of the very few people who had worked through *The Structure of Social Action* at that time – probably am now! … So I knew Parsons quite well, and that was when I was getting married to Esther Goody, and she had written her undergraduate thesis on Parsons, but also her father knew Talcott a little. But anyhow, I knew him quite well ...

PT: But in the long run, you didn't, yourself, take up his more sort of psychological side, because his theory is an attempt to fuse psychological and sociological explanations, isn't that right?

JG: Well, I would say "integrate", which I've always wanted to do … I think Juliet would say that I knew no psychology, and didn't integrate, whereas I thought that the work I did in my thesis on death and the ancestors, which I read parts of Freud for, as well as parts of Marxist writers on law – thanks to Eric Hobsbawm – then I thought that I had used the work on ambivalence, and particularly work on about death, in order to do this, in order to integrate in some way. I don't think many psychologists would recognise this, and particularly Freudian ones, but that did interest me very much. (pp 59-60)

11. Ghana 1950-52
Finding a matrilineal community

I had a family by that time – a wife, at least one child, if not two – and I was determined I had to get over this hump of looking at some other culture, but I didn't want to go out to New Guinea or anywhere like that, it seemed too far, so I opted for somewhere … Well, it wasn't entirely true to say that, it was fortunate because I met a Ghanaian here, and got interested in Ghana... A chap who became the Attorney-General of Ghana at one time. He was the son of a historian, called Joe Reindorf, and his father, I think his father, perhaps, had been one of the first historians of Ghana. Reindorf, a Danish name from Accra. I'd shared a room with Joe, … so when I wanted to go abroad I had an inclination to go there...

I decided to go to Ghana because … partly because I could come back by mail boat, at that time. I mean, it wasn't like nowadays where you can fly out anywhere in 24 hours, or six hours I think it is to Ghana … you took 12 days by steam ship. But I went out, and I went out third class – steerage, as they call it – so that I could come back in the middle to see my family, so I didn't have to be away for two years in one go. So I chose Ghana in that sense, that double sense … it was most convenient to get back, that way... (pp 32-33)

PT: I was wondering whether you could just describe the practical side of going to Ghana and setting yourself up in the field and so on.

JG: Well, I went out on this boat, ... I went on the boat train up to Liverpool, and I was met there by somebody from the Dempster Line, who said to me, "You do realise you're travelling with a lot of black gentlemen?" I said, "Well, I suppose I'll have to get used to that, because I'm going out to study them". So I was allowed to get on, and I got on this boat – it was rather depressing, right down in the hold – and we were allowed up on deck for what, half an hour or an hour every day. But I had very interesting company down there because the Africans I was with, one was going to be a lawyer, one was a doctor - I can't remember the others very much, but they're the people who were in my cabin, so I probably had a lot more intelligent conversation down there than I did up in second or first class with Europeans.

Anyhow, I was met in Ghana by a former student of Meyer Fortes … The former student's name was Kofi Busia, who wrote a book on the Ashanti, and eventually became Prime Minister after Nkrumah, and he was Head of the Sociology Department in Lagos, and he looked after me … I suppose, through having been a prisoner-of-war, and also I felt my age was against me, I wanted to get things done as quickly as I could, so time was very important to me, so I didn't spend long in Accra at that time, in the capital. I got my permits or whatever I had to do, got my kit together, and my food, made my arrangements very quickly - always did. And I always felt the time-swinging chariot was hurrying near, even at that time … (pp 34-35)

Of kit, well, in the short time I had in the South, I got together what I wanted, and wrapped them up, and had them in the back of the lorry that I'd got for a short time from the government, and took it up with me. But, really, all I needed was a bed, and some sort of bath, and a lamp – a pressure lamp – plus food, plus beer.

PT: So you took your own bed with you?

JG: Bed? Yes. Yes, a camp bed. (p 37)

So I hurried up, I went up to Kumasi, which was the … the capital of … the Division of Ashanti, and I met somebody who knew Meyer Fortes quite well there, an administrator in education, called Peter Cannon, and he fixed me up to go further on in a government lorry... Because my Scholarship was a Colonial Office one, so I was going out there as a Colonial Officer. He also found me a cook/steward from the area I was going to, which was most useful. So I went there with him, up to the North, and I stopped the night when I got into the Northern Territories, in a huge government rest house, built of mud, with sticks for a roof, but a vast place, where there was a man – that I remember to this day – the District Officer met me there, a very pleasant chap, and when we got there, said, "Well, we'll have to go out and shoot something for dinner tonight". So we went out and shot a guinea fowl, a wild one, and came back and cooked that.

And then I went on the next day to the next government place, to see the District Commissioner there. And his sister was married to an archaeologist in Cambridge, and he had a huge HMV gramophone – like one of these ones you see in these ads – which he turned up and played music on that, he was very proud of that! So I stayed there, and then went on, the next day, to the place where I was going to work. But even there, I stayed for a time in a rest house, a government rest house, before I went out to the village...

And there I got to know someone who was Headmaster of the local school, from the area, a very intelligent man who later, under Independence, himself became a District Commissioner, but told me a great deal about the area that I was in.

PT: What was his name?

JG: Bni (pronounced Binny) Kunyamini Bni. And he was the son of a chief, somebody who had been a chief round there. He had gone to secondary school... And, anyhow, he knew a great deal about the area, so he oriented me, and suggested I should go down to this place that I eventually went to, called Birifu, which is about 10 miles, 15 miles away from there …

PT: Did you tell him what kind of place you were looking for?

JG: Well, in a sense, I suppose. But I found myself in a bit of a hornets' nest up there because I was looking to work in a certain tribe … Fortes had worked in a strictly patrilineal society, and he wanted me, and I wanted to work in something different, and this one was on the western border of Ghana, and it was partially matrilineal. As I say, it had matrilineal inheritance of [moveable] goods which went from a man to his sister's children, his cattle did, his wealth did. And I wanted to go there.

PT: So you knew that beforehand?

JG: Yes. I knew that before, because there was a certain man who had been a District Officer, from Oxford, called Rattray, who had worked there, had worked in Ashanti, and he did a survey of the North, and published on different tribes in the North, so that you could see something from this. It was rather obscure how it worked, but you could see it was different. So, yes, I wanted these people.

But on the other hand, when I got into this area … I didn't find any fixed terminology for peoples. It was as if there were two terms – one was "lobi", that I wanted, because they were matrilineal, and the other ones were "dogati". But they changed, and sometimes, if you asked in an area, they would say, "Yes, those people over there, they are lobi", or "Those people over there, they are dogati", and if you asked about certain things, like matrilineal inheritance, then matrilineal inheritance was always "lobi". But other things, too, might be "lobi" or they might be "dogati". It wasn't fixed, and therefore it changed. They used the term something like people do as "upper river" people and "lower river" people, and depending where you were, who was upper and who was lower to you, so in a sense I found it very difficult to see where I was, to find out where I was, since it depended on what you were talking about. If you were talking about a certain sort of xylophone, people would be "lobi". In other ways they might be "dogati". So I had a lot of puzzling to do about how to work this out. (pp 35-37)

12. Birifu village: participant observation

PT: But in the village, did you have your own house?

JG: In the village I went to, there was another rest house, which was not used by District Commissioners, because it was only 15 miles away from their Headquarters. There was something there which the local people had built, because they wanted one of the administrators to come out at certain times. They had built it, and it wasn't being used, so I went into that. … But later on I went into a local house, which was vacant for other reasons.

PT: Can you describe that house that you went into?

JG: The second one - yes. They had thick mud walls, flat roofs... and no windows, in fact, that I can think of. And I was just thinking, I probably ate on the roof upstairs, I think. But also, at that second place, it seemed to be very enclosed, this mud hut, and I remember that I had a tent that I borrowed, with me – from the government supplies as well – and I put the tent next to one side of the hut, and I opened up the hut a bit. I took some bricks out and made an entrance, and so I could go under the tent and ... use that as a sort of office, which I did.

PT: Did you cook for yourself?

JG: No, no. Never. Almost never.

PT: So you had a servant for some things?

JG: I had this cook/steward... Man. Always had this cook/steward with me, and wouldn't have done without it, because if you really had to go, as I would have done, as he had to, to the river to get water, which was some way away, to the woods to chop down some wood, you know, before you could light a fire and before you could do cooking, or before you could have made a bath, I would have spent the whole of my time doing that. There was nothing like turning on a tap in any way, you know, or … or lighting a gas oven! They had a lot of work to do... (pp 42-43)

PT: And in terms of the methods? Participant observation? What did that involve? What were you observing?

JG: What was I doing? Well, when I got there, I was in this hut on the top of the hill, and I just went down and started sniffing around one of these compounds, and somebody came out, and was interested in who I was, and I tried to explain I was interested in learning the language – I'm not sure how this happened - because soon afterwards I had to get somebody from the locality who would come round with me. Even when I'd learnt the language I needed somebody who I could check with, because you couldn't write down every word - somebody I could check with when I got back. And so usually I used to go around with this chap, but I could go down by myself, and did go down by myself, and quite often I used to sit there drinking beer by myself, and I could soon understand enough of the language. But I couldn't learn the language beforehand, I had to learn the language there, on the spot. Ordinary things I learnt fairly quickly, but obviously the meaning of religious concepts, took some time, and, indeed, I don't know that I understand them altogether now...

I went to funerals a great deal, and partly because funerals, a lot of people gathered there, funerals summed up a person's life in a biographical way – what he'd done during his time on earth and this sort of thing – and also people had time to discuss things with you, so that you could sit there talking about inheritance in a relatively natural way, about this and that, and about quarrels that people had had, and so on, in a natural way, so that was very useful for me, to go to those. Also they lasted three days and three nights...

PT: Were you able to visit people and maybe eat with them in their houses?

JG: Oh yes. Certainly would drink with them in their houses. The great thing was, in that area, that every day there was a certain house that brewed beer, which meant you could go there and buy it, and other people would be seen round drinking beer, so it's like going to a pub. So sit around with the other people, and the conversation would be completely natural, you know. You could direct it, or they'd direct it. So that was very easy.

PT: What about observing women's roles, how would you do that?

JG: Well, the women had a role, of course, some role, even in drinking. That is to say they were the brewers of beer, and they would serve it and sell it to you. There was also nothing to stop women sitting around drinking beer with you. In fact, that was quite common, and if you were well in with the woman, or she was in with you, you would drink out of a calabash, you would drink together - she would drink on one side, you on the other side. But looking at the other aspects of women's work and women's activities, you certainly didn't interact with them in the same way as you did with men, except there was nothing much to stop you. It was not a Muslim area, and nothing to stop you walking into the kitchen, and sitting down there and looking at things, or going to the harvest or planting ground where women were working in the field, there was nothing to stop you doing that, or perhaps in the market place. But inevitably there'd be a slightly moral problem...

PT: How close to a woman could you get? If a woman, for instance, became an anthropologist's lover, would that be a dangerous situation, do you think?

JG: It was always said to be. It was always said to make difficulties. I mean, you're in a relatively small village, and villages in Africa are relatively small, compared with a village in India - a village in India is huge, often. Everybody knows everybody else in an African village, so they know directly if somebody visits you, or you visit somebody. There isn't any privacy in that sense.

I mean, to lead a private life, you're in danger of being accused of witchcraft. I always used to hide myself, not hide myself, but not be out in the open if I was writing field notes, which I did for a large part of the day, of course. I used to reckon I had to fill up ten pages a day, of field notes, but I didn't like to do that in public anyway, because I thought they would think this private activity was rather like witchcraft. So I was … so if you're down in the village, and somebody's sitting there, brooding away, you would wonder what they were up to, unless they were interacting with people. (pp 37-41)

13. The Myth of the Bagré

PT: I think you've even said that it was the thing you were most proud of. Is that right?

JG: Yes, I think so. A translation. I took such a lot of time and work in doing that. I used to drive … to London from here, every weekend, to work with my friend down there... He was called Kumbuno Ganda, from the village, "Kum". But he came over here to work here, and I used to go and work with him every weekend … I was very pleased to have done it, partly because it threw such a different light on things for me, particularly the learning process, because I had thought that this myth was fairly standardised – that's what I was told – but I really didn't understand, at that time, what "sameness" meant, if you didn't have ... a written copy. So it was a great surprise to me, and an even greater surprise to my co-worker, when these versions turned out to be so different from one another. So that led me to query, very much - I should have known that from my work on oral societies, but I didn't really appreciate, and it made me query, very much, the kind of analysis on myth that my friend Claude Levi-Strauss did, because I then realised there wasn't simply one version that was linked with society, there were several – I mean, an infinite number – and that people with creative abilities had been much underplayed, and until we had a tape-recorder like this, of course, we couldn't really tell. The great effort of writing down one version - you'd raise your hands and say, "Not another!" But when you've got one of these, you realise that each recording is different. And it adds up to being significantly different.

PT: The first time you recorded was without a machine.

JG: Yes, was when I had no recording machine. I did by hand. … And the first time I did recordings was some years later, in Gonja, in a different area, where I got flown a machine from the BBC... But that was so heavy that you needed somebody to carry it around if you haven't got a car. It was only later on that the portable tape-recorder turned up, and I then went with my friend, Kumbuno, back to the first place I'd been to, and made some recordings at that time, and we've recorded ever since...

PT: But what was the role of Benima Dagarti?

JG: He was the person who first came out with me and said that he knew this myth, and he recited me it - the first version – and I had a pencil and paper, carbon paper, and I

wrote out everything as he recited it. But after that I used a recorder. The recorded versions, incidentally, for whatever reason, are always shorter than the ones that I've written by hand. I think he probably explained more as he was going along, and writing out like that. Also he had to wait for me to finish my script at the time. But that took me something like ten days to record, so I wouldn't have done that again unless I had a tape-recorder, and I wouldn't have known the versions differed over time.

PT: Was the myth a secret, or in the open?

JG: It was I suppose secret. It was only available to initiates in the society. And even when I took my tape-recorder there subsequently, I had to leave the tape-recorder with my friend in one room, and I had to go to another. … So it was certainly secret in that sense, it was limited in that sense, to those members who had been through the initiation procedures – which I never went through fully.

PT: You did start, then, did you?

JG: Well, I did some of the sacrifices, but it meant sitting, in theory, naked, for a week - or was it two weeks? And that didn't seem, to me, the best way of using my grant! In silence, I should say. That didn't seem, to me, the best way of doing it, and I wasn't quite sure what extra I would learn. (pp 42-44)

14. Vansina and oral tradition

PT: So you were sceptical about that whole school of African history based on oral traditions?

JG: Yes. I was. I did think that there were some things in which you could repeat information and hand it down over time, and I think Vansina was okay in terms of royal dynastic records in that way, and I recorded, myself, a few in Ashanti, which were repeated by remembrances. But by and large, I thought that insufficient attention had been paid to the fact that if you were recounting a myth, as distinct from a dynastic

history, if you were recounting myth and it was a long recitation, that you couldn't remember this exactly, and that you were liable to fill in passages that you couldn't remember, and to re-create the passage. And I thought the aspect of creation, of creating literature in simple societies, was very much underplayed. As I say, there was no reason why people should repeat the same thing over and over again, and if they couldn't remember it, they would make something else up at the time. (p 67)

15. The anthropologist in local politics

I wasn't very active. I did join a local CVP [Convention People's Party] which was Nkrumah's Party. I did join that, yes, because I was in favour of Independence for these countries. But I didn't really do much else.

PT: I guess some people would say that anthropologists ought to stay neutral in the field. What's your feeling about that?

JG: Well, I didn't think it would make much difference. But anyhow, at the time, I thought it would be useful to attend these local meetings, and that was the only way I could do so. So I was interested in seeing what was going on. No doubt if the opposition Party had also been there, canvassing the area, I might have joined that as well! But my sympathies were more with the CVP at that time. Yes, I think that if you're in a political situation, which was very divided, possibly, yes, you would be better to remain apart in any quarrel, but you hoped to take that with a pinch of salt in that, unless you get in a little to whatever the situation is – domestic or national – you aren't going to learn anything, and so you hope to get a certain way towards the conflict situation, I think, in order to be able to report on it at all. And you can only bring out the fact that you are related to one Party, or you had something to do with one Party rather than another …

PT: You could argue, perhaps, that it's important to show people you're on their side, in order to gain their confidence...

JG: Well, I think that's true, except that if the situation is very divisive, to be on somebody's side means to be you're against somebody else, and that does make it

difficult, I think. That does make it difficult. But I think one just has to judge these situations as they come, and to be relatively open about which side you're on – if there is a question of sides. (pp 45-46)

16. Returning to Ghana

PT: So did you go out regularly to Ghana?

JG: Yes, because, you see, I did my second lot of fieldwork with young children, and my second wife, Esther, who is out there now, … I went out there for another two years, to work among the Gonja, which Esther wrote up, really, for her Ph.D., but I did a lot of work there, largely historical work, which I have never done anything with... And I was fairly closely attached to Lagos, the Institute of African Studies, which was then directed by my friend Thomas Hodgkin... I went out sometimes for my own reasons – to record the Bagré, or to do something – so I kept on fairly regularly, yes. I can't remember, now, the last time I went back. Oh, I went back with Juliet a while ago, to go to a conference, but I didn't go up North. The last time I went up North I can't remember, but it was certainly probably with Kum, my friend Kum – that was some years ago. It was - I found increasingly difficult. I mean, I was not attached to the government or anything, or the University, so I had to find my own way around, and finding your own way around Africa meant jumping on and off buses in the heat, or else climbing on lorries, and I found this very tiring to do, and not conducive to doing much work, whereas before, when I had the Colonial Scholarship, I got ferried around … and that was much easier. It's not an easy place to get around now, unless you've got a lot of money and can buy a car or hire one. (pp 48-49)

I, myself, have seen societies very much as divided, for example, by the plough. I mean, the introduction of the plough in the part of Africa where I was, seemed, to me, enormously important. That is to say, instead of hoeing up some patch of land the size of this courtyard here, which is all you could do with a hoe, that when you used animal traction and put a plough behind an ox or a horse, you could go from here, you know, right to Newport or further in one ploughing operation.

PT: And was that just beginning, then, when you were there?

JG: Yes. There was one man who was doing it in Ghana when I was there, in Northern Ghana, in the area that I was, and I saw the revolutionary effects this had on land tenure, for example, when he was the only man to have got a plough and oxen, which he got from the missionaries, and everybody thought this was a wonderful thing. So it was, but, obviously, in order to do this, he ploughed up unused land. It was land which was used for pastoral purposes, which sheep and goats wandered in, animals used for hunting, and, of course, he made claims to a huge amount of land – which happens under plough conditions. And that was one of the very important things to me, there was the difference between inheritance and marriage, and stratification in Eurasia, which had a plough, and Africa, which did not have a plough, and still doesn't have a plough in many parts. … Hoe agriculture is still important. And the revolutionary effects of the plough seemed, to me, very important. … Because if each man is hoeing, you can't have much difference between you and me in how much we hoe, but if we've got a plough, if you have a plough and I'm still hoeing, there's an enormous amount of difference between the two, and a great stratification gap immediately rises up. And to my mind that made a difference, or one of the differences, between who you married, because obviously your daughter was going to be much more important than my daughter, because your daughter was going to stand to inherit that amount – a large amount of land and a plough – whereas mine was going to inherit a small patch of land. So that seemed to me very important, and that is what endeared me to Gordon Childe and the plough coming in in Bronze Age society, and at the same time class divisions appearing – economic class divisions appearing in an important sense, in that way. (pp 72-73)

17. Anthropology and sociology

Approaches to social research

PT Maybe we could start by just something about your views on methods, in general? Methods of research - what are the appropriate methods of research, and how your view is different from those of other social scientists.

JG: Well, I've always been very eclectic as to methods. As I say, but when I went to Africa, I obviously did as other anthropologists. I spent two years in a village, working on that. I also worked on the records quite a lot in Ghana, Ghana National Archives, and in the PRO.

PT: Historical records?

JG: Yes. I haven't done a lot with them, but I've got an enormous number of notes and microfilms...

PT: And did you do a survey, a quantitative survey, when you were in Ghana? Like a household survey?

JG: Yes. Oh yes, I certainly did that, on one locality. Well, more than one, where I was living at a certain time, I certainly did a household survey at that time. Yes, I did...

And then I became very interested in comparative work, firstly in Ghana, in Northern Ghana, where my supervisor, Meyer Fortes, was quite interested in comparative work ... but I rapidly became interested in other forms of comparison, and primarily, first of all it was the comparison of societies that hadn't got writing with those that had, and that led me, of course, to Europe really, which is the only place I knew much about...

Very early on I was interested in the literacy thing because my friend, Ian Watt, that wrote this book on *The Rise of the Novel*, was interested in this problem, and he, like me had been a prisoner-of-war, when reading material was non-existent or was very scarce - he had been a prisoner-of-war in Burma, and so he had become interested in the absence of writing, and the absence of books and things, and we were both interested in that... And then he became interested in … er … well, he became interested in what happened in Ancient Greece, and so did I, as a result of this, and we produced an article at the time, which we called, "The Consequences of Literacy", in which we attributed much more than we should have done to Ancient Greece, and not enough to other forms of writing. But anyhow, it was much too Europeanist in approach. … At that time, we were trying to get rid of the idea that there was some spirit in Ancient Greece, or some genius in Ancient

Greece, and looking at it, and trying to link it up with the invention of the alphabet – what had happened there – which was not altogether untrue, I think, but it certainly wasn't the whole truth, and we played down the role of the alphabet in other societies other than Greece – that is, in Phoenicia – and we certainly played down the role of other forms of writing. So that was one thing that led me into comparative work.

And the other was the inheritance system that I mentioned to you, …the matrilineal and patrilineal. ... I was interested in this, and interested in the problem of the contrast of this, with what I called "dowry systems" – "bride worth systems" in Africa, and "dowry systems" in Europe and Asia – dowry systems in which women were often entitled to a portion, not necessarily an equal portion, by any means, but a portion of the property. And that they, too, were endowed. They were endowed at marriage, and sometimes also in inheritance, and particularly if there are no males, they would inherit the property, whereas in Africa, if there are no brothers, it went to cousins - it went, in other words, it went to other males further apart. So I was very interested in this, and the difference it made, and the difference it made to marriage systems too. So that was the first marriage work I did...

It was only later on, when I came back from that [Ghana], that I began seriously doing comparative work, and I started by working on Murdoch's *Ethnographic Atlas*, which you've probably seen in *Ethnology*, … in order to test out some ideas about what the difference was between dowry systems and bride wealth systems, as far as demography and other things were concerned. So I worked on those, which was very unfashionable really, in anthropology – in British anthropology – because there was, of course, this crazy emphasis on fieldwork, which there still is, which was very good, but they rejected other methods. So I was interested in other methods... I spent quite a long time collecting comparative demographic material on on family size, and I was very interested in "stopping rules", in when people stopped having children, and I argue that with with dowry systems, in which you had a restricted amount of resources, that you would tend to have cut off points in the number of children that you had, whereas in Africa, by and large it didn't seem, to me, that there were cut off points... (pp 63-65)

PT: I think you believe in the unity of the social sciences. Is that right?

JG: I think I probably need notice to re-think that particular question, but I was very much influenced by the work towards what's called *The Unified Encyclopaedia of the Social Sciences*, which was started in Chicago, and which published various things … They were little blue pamphlets which were going to come out as an encyclopaedia later on, but never did. … and these were important. And I suppose one thing about Parsons and *The Structure of Social Action*, and the endeavour of the Human Relations Department at Harvard was to bring together sociology and psychology and anthropology.

PT: Do you think there's any advantage in the division between anthropology and sociology?

JG: Almost none. Well, I mean, I think there is some advantage in that people seem to be able to speak to each other more closely in anthropology...

PT: You use this phrase, "The heavy curtains of institutionalised boundaries between disciplines."

JG: Yes. I've always thought that that was terrible, but when I see efforts to get out of that, I've not always been satisfied. But that's because I, myself, would like to be able to pick and choose. ... I can see there's another level which you might want to join those people who want to spend their lives looking at a village society, and those who want to spend their lives looking at some factory organisation, so I think there might be some rationale for a division of that kind. But I think, intellectually, it's not very satisfactory, and … You know, there's got to be cross-cutting ties between these fields, even if you do think that fieldwork is critical of an intensive character is critical in the one, and not so critical in the other - the other is more statistical, more numerical in that way. But I do feel one ought to be looking for links at an intellectual level - one ought to be looking for links between the disciplines, even if, you know, as a discipline, psychology does require different things from sociology, nevertheless there is a point at which these things link up. (pp 68-70)

18. Binary contrasts

PT: You're very against "binary contrasts" aren't you. Could you say something about that?

JG: Well, I just think they were at a certain time mainly as a result of working in linguistics applied to anthropology, especially in the work of Levi-Strauss, in which the whole business of "binary contrast" was blown up and made the key to understanding particular groups, and you got these attempts to produce columns – usually headed "Male" or "Female", "Left", "Right", "Sun", "Moon", something like this - that went down, as if that summed up the total context of society. And it had some complicated arrangement too, complicated matter to do with Levi-Strauss's concept of structure, which led in various directions, but one of them was to do with these forms of binary division. They were particularly associated with the professor in Oxford – Needham – in this country. And I found this very trivial.

Not that there isn't some aspect of it which is perfectly correct,... but it didn't allow enough for ambiguity. The fact, for example, that a xylophone player among the LoDagaba was always known as a left-handed man,... and, therefore, he was assumed to have female characteristics. And I didn't see, at all, this was necessarily true, and there was this tendency to say that in the two columns, this binary opposition, that black was opposed to white, that black was associated with night, with witchcraft, and with women. … Whereas I thought that the use of language, and the use of thought, was much more flexible than that: that you had to be prepared to think that black was not only witchcraft, but was also beautiful, under circumstances, especially in Africa, so black rain cloud or the black earth was what you wanted, was for fertility. It was not simply negative, and to be associated with witchcraft and so on and so on. So I thought that was much too facile. Fortunately it's a form of analysis which had its day, and which is no longer in fashion. Binary analysis - that is what I meant by binary analysis.

I don't mean that I didn't see any gross divisions between, say, literate accounts and purely oral ones. I mean, I think that is, again, is simplified in the sense that means of communication are always adding on to one another, that is to say literacy, writing adds

on to oral communication, just as electronic communication adds on to writing. It doesn't displace the book, it adds on to the book and makes it more complicated. It modifies the book, just as to my mind, the existence of reading and writing modified orality, so that the oral in post-Bronze Age societies, was never the same as the oral in earlier societies. You've always got to look at the oral in our society as being - important as it is – as being related to the literate as well. That is, it doesn't exist on its own, it exists in relation to the literate, so that there are contexts in which literate communication is considered appropriate, and others in which oral communication is appropriate, but even then the oral one is influenced by, I think, by the literate communication. So that's what I meant really, in saying that I was against that sort of analysis ... But that's all I meant. (pp 71-72)

19. Inheritance

Inheritance. I spoke to you a bit about that, about the fact that, out there, I was interested in the patrilineal and matrilineal inheritance, but what interested me, when I compared it with European inheritance, ... the fact that even in matrilineal societies, it wasn't going to a woman, it was going to a man – it was going to your sister's son. It was going through a woman, but it wasn't a woman that was inheriting the property. … Daughters inherited from their mothers. Men, in patrilineal societies, passed to their sons, and in matrilineal societies, they went to their sisters' sons, whereas in Europe you had a different system. … Women didn't necessarily inherit, but they were endowed at marriage, they were given their portion – a word which I always thought was highly significant, "portion" - they were given their portion, which was not perhaps as much as a man was getting, sometimes it was, but it did, in a significant sense, belong to them. So it moved around like Eleanor of Aquitaine moved it around, or with our present Queen, who, as a woman, inherited the crown. And that you weren't getting in the areas of Africa that I was working in, because, as I say, you will always find a man, a more distant man, in the same clan, say a cousin, who would inherit, rather than a woman. So we never got the situations that you got in Europe and Asia, where you got the situation of the woman inheriting the property and bringing a man in to marry … Yes, to bring a man in, like Prince Philip... that would be inconceivable, I think. And that was very interesting to me that that happened. And I related to that a bit too, the fact that under the relatively egalitarian system in Africa – not always egalitarian by any means – but it didn't matter much who you married, but it

mattered very much in Europe and Asia, and … what a wife was going to bring in to the "conjugal pool", as they called it...

In Africa,... you don't get inheritance going to the woman in any of the matrilineal societies. You get them going through the woman to the woman's son, but it's always to a male, so the woman is not, herself, independent, whereas you can argue that in Europe and Asia, a woman who is an heiress, as in Ancient Greece, is important in her own right, and for the property she owns, and therefore she can attract somebody to marry her. You see, if you're an heiress – and this made a lot of difference – if you were an heiress in Ancient Greece, you had to marry your cousin, as in an Arab marriage – your father's brother's son - you had to marry, because you didn't want the property to go out of the family, and that was because the woman had a right to that property. Before it went to a more distant cousin, it went downward to her, before it went sideways and out to a more distant cousin. So I think that one has to be very careful about matrilineal societies. It's true there are some which are what I call "matriarchal" in that sense, in which the woman has the power, and her property goes to other women. But this is not the case with matrilineal societies in Africa, I think. (pp 76-77)

20. Literacy

I went to town on that! … That dated almost before I went to the field. And certainly when I went to the field, I can remember Ian Watt urging me to look at what was happening in a society without writing... So that was a sort of permanent interest I had, really, in the difference that writing made. And later on, I suppose, I was interested not only in writing, but the different forms of writing, and so I became more interested, but I think that's more recently in the fact that, well, I thought the first thesis that Watt and I put forward was a very Europeanist thesis... What we didn't take cognisance of at the time, was the fact that the Phoenicians, after all, invented a system of alphabetic writing, and that the Bible, itself, was written in an alphabetic... form of writing initially, and that this form of writing, of course, spread to India through the Aramaic script, and and stimulated much in India. And then there was the form of logographic script.

I think we were thinking much too much in evolutionary lines at that time, thinking about the alphabetic script as emerging from a logographic one – such as you find in Mesopotamia, or in Egypt, or in China - which we thought of as being less progressive than the alphabet. But on the other hand, what subsequently impressed me about China was that this one script meant that this large empire was held together by one system of writing. I have seen people from Canton trying to communicate with people from Beijing, and writing down their communication and passing it. They wouldn't understand orally, but they understand in writing, so the whole of the bureaucracy, and the whole of the maintaining that huge country together, was really much easier to having a logographic script. … They did that, so they kept their local cultures. Whereas in America, it had a large empire, a large country like that, but only through institutionalising English - everything else was brushed away – German, French - everybody had to learn English. You had one language, which you didn't have in China. And of course, in the European Union, they tried to keep the diversity and not have one language or one script, but at enormous cost, whereas China does it through that, and that's through having a non-alphabetic system of writing that they did this. So Lenin was quite wrong when he said that the alphabet is going to be the revolution of the East, and we thought, because it was so difficult for us to learn... When I recently went – well, a few years ago – to Japan, ... they said, "But the future is not in your European alphabet", well, Middle Eastern alphabet, "The future is in characters like we have."... They thought that Chinese was the way of the future, and not the alphabet – unlike Lenin – and that made me rethink some aspects of East and West in that...

[When we] thought about production, and modes of production, we never equally thought about modes of communication, and I think we ought to, and I think they were important for human history in many ways. … Really, in talking about world history, ever give such an emphasis to this, that we thought too much about the modes of production, which were important, but modes of communication are also important. And, I would add, since this relationship – technology and the state – modes of destruction seem, to me, also important. (pp 81-83)

21. Food and culture

I thought, there, you could not make a difference between culture in Europe and culture in Asia, because food in China, and food in India, was at least as complicated, if not more so, than food in Western Europe. And so I wanted to look at that... and I thought that the discussion of food in Africa... didn't take into account the fundamental differences in agriculture in Africa and in Europe and Asia – that is the presence or absence of the plough, if you want to put it that way - and the writing. And I thought that food in Europe and Asia, when you had first of all the specialisation which our plough agriculture had permitted, and also on the recording and elaboration, which writing, again, permitted - so starting from this point of view, I tried to analyse the differences with Africa – but not only with Europe, but also with Europe and East Asia...

I always thought that in Africa the food was very much the same one day as another, and so it was porridge and soup, porridge and sauce – not so very different from what my Scottish ancestors lived on, I'm sure! However, they, too, had a very low standard of living, whereas in Asia, what you got was this elaboration of food, particularly among merchants, and among the bourgeoisie classes, ... and it was clear that they were elaborating these things for status and other reasons, also, of course, they delighted in new recipes, whereas in Africa you never got that kind of thing. If you went to a chief's house, you'd eat the same kind of food, perhaps more of it, perhaps a bit more meat than you got in a peasant's house, or in any other house. There was no cultural differentiation really, or very little, as regards food, in terms of whether you were a chief or whether you were a farmer. Whereas I thought that in Europe and Asia, you got differentiation of food between peasant food and the food that was elaborated in merchant regimes or in noble regimes or the middle classes, you got a stratification in food coming out then. So I was interested in this.

And I was interested in this stratification which I didn't see as being related to class in Europe, in the Marxist sense, as much as being related to differences related to the means of production, and the means of communication, as appears in the Bronze Age in Europe. So I always thought the Bronze Age was very important in allowing a different form of differentiation, and here I relied very much on the work of Gordon Childe, and it made me think, very much, that European sociologists and historians were wrong to think about the divergence of Far Eastern and European economies later on. Early on, when in the

Bronze Age, they had been very similar – they had writing, they had the plough, they had various things – so that China developed along, in a sense, parallel lines to Europe. I think we're seeing that now with the upsurge of China and the upsurge of India. So that's how I became interested in that.

I was also interested in the talk about "love". That was a subsidiary theme, but it was also to do with the fact that I was not at all convinced that the Europeans – the French troubadours – invented love, that (a) you went back to Ovid and to classical forms, and (b) you went very much to Islam, and Islam was important partly because, through Spain, it probably influenced the troubadours, and influenced the expression of love in poetry, in the south of of Europe, both in Palermo and in Andalucia. So that … the importance to me was that Europe was not unique in the way that many historians and sociologists had wanted to make it unique, that anything that emerged in the economy, in terms of capitalism, was less to do with the kind of things that Weber talked about, much more to do with the changes in economy in industrialisation, and this enterprise of his, to look for the Protestant Ethic and a non-Protestant Ethic, also seems to be the wrong kind of thing because there seem to be equivalents of these Protestant Ethics in other societies – the Taliban, for example, who were busy destroying pictures and refusing to play cards and go to the cinema. So I thought there was much more similarity in the Eurasian field than Marx had given credit for - not only Marx, but Weber and many others...

So that led me on, really, to my recent book on *The Theft of History* (2007), because I thought that Europe … had claimed, and particularly the history of modernisation for itself, which was perfectly all right if they simply went back to the 16th century, to the Renaissance, but going back further than that, as Marx did, or Weber did, they thought that was essentialist, and looked back to an almost racist view of civilisations, which was not acceptable in the modern age. So that's why I wrote about the theft of history... (pp 86-88)

22. Discourses of love

PT: So when you talk about food and love, you really mean food and marriage? You're not talking about sexuality and food?

JG: No. No, I'm not talking sexuality in that sense. No, I'm talking about food and love which leads to marriage. Yes. And well, in a sense there is an aspect of love, there is an aspect of love in it, in that demographers talk very much about love marriages, and one significant thing for them, in Western Europe, was a free choice of marriage – a love marriage in that sense. So freedom of choice in that. But I felt that even where you got that possibility in Europe, nevertheless the number of arranged marriages you get – see Jane Austen – was pretty high. Arranged marriages between members of the same class, and it's quite true that you may have slightly more freedom of choice, but the level of choice was restricted. And in Africa, or India, for example, in Africa you got much more arrangement in marriage, more arrangement of marriage, but you certainly got the possibility of people making a free choice, especially in second marriages, of which you got a very high level, because you got frequent divorce in most cases. And so love in that sense – in the sense of free choice of partner – certainly did exist there... There was some difference, but certainly not the difference that Malthus or others would make between prescription on one side, and freedom on the other. This idea, you know, that we are free and everybody else is in bonds, … seemed to me very very frail...

PT: You say, in *Food and Love*, you say, "In black Africa, generally one does not find much development of a discourse of love".

JG: Yes, because I was very impressed with the fact that "discourse of love" arose very often in poetry, or in letter writing, letter writing to somebody at a distance. You do not normally go up to your wife and say, "I love you", but if she went away for a month or two, you wrote this in a letter. And I thought the elaboration of discourse in writing … happened much more in Europe and Asia than it did in Africa, that you got the elaboration of a discourse of love – a discourse in the sense of writing down to somebody at a distance – and that most love poetry was to somebody at a distance, whether it was here or in Ancient Egypt or in China. It was to a soldier gone off to the war, or something like this, or something at a distance, and that seemed, to me, an occasion for an elaboration of discourse of love... And it seemed to be that in Africa, in a purely oral context, in a purely oral context, that there was less occasion for this kind of elaboration of emotion than you got in Europe or in Asia.

PT: How would they express emotion, then?

JG: Well they would certainly express it verbally, but one has to remember that all of oral contact is face-to-face, never anything else. So you say it to somebody, "I want you", or something like that. "Will you be my lover?" or something like this. But it's very much a face-to-face contact, it's not the impersonal contact that comes through letter writing in that way. So that if you move away to another town, there's nothing you can say to your wife that you've left behind. You can't elaborate a discourse to her in any sense, in that way. It just has to remain dormant, or internalised, if you like. I mean, I'm not saying that one is stronger than another, or I think you could talk yourself into certain things, but you haven't got any way of communicating that love at a distance, at a social distance, you can only do it in face-to-face situations.

PT: So you wouldn't argue that you have to have a discourse of love to have the feelings of love?

JG: No, although I think they interact with one another, that you interact with what you write about and what you read in a rather different way, and not that you don't feel love. I mean, you may well feel love, you certainly don't elaborate in the same kind of way. And … no, I think you do get it in song, you get it in song sometimes, when somebody's singing about their lover... You get a minimal amount in that, ... you get the face-to-face interaction, but you don't get the letter writing, or the sending of poems to somebody at a distance, or somebody who can read, is a totally different situation... I'm not saying that face-to-face love is not equally love, but it can't be elaborated in the same way. (pp 94-95)

23. The culture of flowers

Flowers was rather similar to cooking, in the sense that, just as I find no haute cuisine in Africa, … you never had domestication of flowers. You had some flowers in Africa, growing wild in the forest, but you didn't have the sort of thing that you have in Asia or in Europe, but mostly in Asia, as chrysanthemums being planted for sacred and to offer

either to a god or to a human being, or to decorate the house, or decorate the garden, but that sort of aesthetic activity – if you want to take aesthetic cultivation – was not really practised...

I remember one Japanese anthropologist, who I knew well …Junzo Kawada.... I remember Junzo saying that when he first went to Upper Volta, being Japanese he looked around, and he asked the chief, "Where are you growing flowers?" And the chief looked at him as though he was mad! "Why should we grow flowers? You can't eat them". And the idea that you should be planting and growing things which you couldn't eat in that way was incomprehensible to him. … You didn't even get any fruit trees in Africa. You never got the domestication of fruit trees, except one in South Africa, I think, and the idea of growing a peach tree, simply so you could cut it down and display it at the beginning of the New Year, as many families did - most of the families did in Hong Kong - you cut down a peach tree, which is a growing tree, which could have fruit on, that would have horrified my Presbyterian mother, let alone an African, since I was never allowed to break down a branch off an apple tree, let alone a cherry tree. But they are in China and Japan, and now here, you're … growing fruit trees for flowering – not for their fruit, but for the flowers on them – and you're growing chrysanthemums and so on, which were very important. So I was interested in that...

The West rejected the growing of flowers at one time. … What I'm thinking of is mainly to do with the growing of roses around Roman graveyards . And the Protestants, the Christians, of course, were particularly against that, they were particularly against the growing of things in graveyards. … Do you remember a graveyard in the Protestant United States, in the Eastern United States? There's not a flower to be seen. There's not even a cut flower to be seen, except possibly around a patriot's grave. Scotland is the same, you do not see many flowers in the graveyards up there. And the Protestants kept out flowers out of the graveyards, the Catholics brought them in. But … I think Protestant Europe didn't have them very much... Because, ... if you're growing these things, or presenting these things, you're presenting them to the dead - you're worshipping the dead instead of worshipping God … There's another reason for the Protestant one, and that was to do with the Protestant Ethic that Weber talks about. That

as my mother would say, in Scotland, if they go with flowers, you say, "I'd rather hae eggs". I think it's changing very much now.

PT: How long have you been interested in flowers?

JG: Well, once again, as I was cooking, I don't do a hell of a lot in the garden – not that we have much of a garden now, in any case! And it was more the idea of flowers rather than the flowers themselves.... (pp 96-97)

So I was interested, then, in the symbolism of flowers, and the changing symbolism, and the fact that they could change so relatively easily to be a flower of happiness to being a flower of death.

PT: And that's why you investigated the rise of a secret language of flowers?

JG: Yes, that's part of it. That's certainly part of it. But I was interested in that also, from the point of view of literacy as well, because I thought the elaboration of something as complex as that, as a language of flowers, with every flower given a single meaning – not just a general one – so that one flower did this, one flower did that, you could make a bouquet up, as you did in 19th century England, made a bouquet up to give to a girl, with a number of flowers meaning, you know, "I love you. Meet me behind the gasworks tonight" or something like that! And it was, indeed, a language in that sense. I thought that was only possible in urban society, with writing. You might get a single reference in our society, but to have something systematised like that, I could only see that happening in an urban culture with writing. It seemed, to me, typical of what might happen in an urban culture. So once again, I was concerned with literacy in that language of flowers, very much. (pp 98-99)

24. New fieldwork for The Culture of Flowers

PT: I have the impression that you were doing quite a lot of fieldwork for this book...
So did you keep field notes for it?

JG: Oh yes. I've just put them down into the library of St. John's. Yes, I did. … When I especially went to China, to look for the use of flowers on festive occasions, and see this cutting down of a peach tree, for example.

PT: Was that the New Year in South China?

JG: Yes, the Chinese New Year. They would cut down … a peach tree just like we cut a fir tree, but one in full bloom. In fact, the prosperity of your shop could be told by the prosperity of your bloom that was in the window. But that amazed me, that people would cut down fruit trees in that way. And then I did a certain amount of work in the United States also, looking at cemeteries, both in the East and the West of the United States... In the East, on All Saints Day, I sat around a Catholic cemetery … as well as a Protestant. A Protestant one I didn't expect to find anything, but … the Catholics, in Baltimore, a Catholic cemetery there, I sat round, and nobody came there, except a Polish, to a Polish grave, to plant flowers, and they were obviously European migrants that had come recently. But local Catholics behaved like Protestants...

PT: Now, were you especially invited to India for this research on flowers?

JG: I especially went to do it there on India, yes. … I went to Ahmadabad, but I'd been there before. I'd spent some months in a village near Ahmadabad... When I was working on flowers, I went out to India in order to look at flower markets, and to find out where the flowers were produced, because all this use of flowers for religious or cuisine purposes, requires a great organisation of production behind it. It means … it's not only individuals that are growing flowers in their garden, but it's these flower markets that are producing these multi-floral flowers for garlands... …

I've got a garland hanging in there. In the cupboard. And that was because … when I retired I gave a farewell seminar, which was the first one I'd ever done on flowers, and two people at the back of the room, one was a friend of mine, who has now become Director of the Courtauld Museum, and another Indian lady that I knew very well, they made me a garland. Sitting there, they wove a garland...

But yes, I did go out to India. And I went to China, too, for the first time, to find out about flowers. … I was asked to go to Japan, but I did some work on flowers when I was there. (p 105)

When I was in America I used to do observation of flowers – in the East … New Haven and Baltimore – and also in Brazil. I went to flower markets in Brazil. … Sao Paulo... Sao Paulo I lived near a cemetery, and I went to the flower market, which, incidentally, was largely Japanese. And in India I went, too, to the flower market in Ahmadabad, I spent some time in the flower market there.

PT: Yes, we were talking about that. I'm just wondering whether you've got more involved, in a way, with this topic, in a broader sense, because it's a mixture of your own African experience, history, new ethnography. Was it, for you, a special experience doing that project?

JG: Well, I suppose it was, because I did it when I retired... And, of course, since I'd retired, I could spend full time on it. (pp 120-21)

25. Living in an Indian village, 1977

I didn't know enough about Asia, and I wanted to know something about Asia … I felt I wanted to stay in a village in India. And, part of the difference, I discovered, was when I went to visit India, I was in a small town of three or four thousand people. In Africa, where I was, that was a large town. There wasn't anything larger... The villages in Africa, you see, are three or four hundred people, and that makes quite a difference in terms of the organisation of social life. Lavatories, for example – you just went out in the field, you couldn't do that in India – it was much more concerned with purity and so on, in India.

PT: So how did you choose this particular village?

JG: Well, I chose it because my friends, the Sarabhais, were Jains, who were cotton millers - the family were cotton millers - and he was a scientist who came over to St. John's, and his wife was a fantastic Indian dancer. I knew them, and I knew some members of the family quite well – they were a particularly interesting family. But I didn't want to spend it with them, because in the first place they were Jains, in the second place they were merchants, and I wanted to go to a village, so I asked them to find me a house in a village nearby. Because I didn't have much time to look around myself, since I was only going, I think, in one summer vacation, for three months. I used to count my time here in the summer - examinations used to take place in the middle of June, and I used to go away a week or so later to Africa or to India. I did a lot of fieldwork, a lot of time I spent away.

So I went to India, and they found me a house which belonged to a family of school teachers, … which was near Ahmadabad. It was in a high class section of the village – a Brahmin section –and that made for some difficulties. In terms of the people I could have come to see me, although my intellectual friends in Ahmadabad or elsewhere, would speak of the lack of importance of caste in India, it was of overall importance. … I can remember, in this village, I wanted to speak to some weavers, and I said something to the head man of the village, who was a Patel – a farmer - and a member of Congress and so on, about wanting to interview some people from this, from the weaving caste, and he said – which I didn't want – "Well, I'll bring some over to speak to you". I didn't want that. I wanted to go and talk to them, which I did eventually. Anyhow, he arranged for some to come over, which I thought was a good preliminary move, and we had tea together. But for these chaps, when they came, he brought broken plates, broken saucers, and cups which had been broken – the handles had been broken – old ones which weren't being used. And this was a Congressman.... And the people there, from this sub-caste, these untouchables, could not go to the same well as the other people, they had their own well, and this was in a Congress village, with Congress people. There was an enormous amount of discrimination. ... Even in this time, in a Congress village, a Patel village, there was incredible discrimination against the untouchable caste. (pp 108-109)